THE MEMOIRS OF

THE RT. HON.

SIR ANTHONY EDEN

K.G., P.C., M.C.

FULL CIRCLE



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FOREWORD

I began to think of writing a book about my years in office after my operation in the spring of 1957. My first intention was to proceed with it in the accepted order of time, from the early nineteen-thirties until the present day.

This method had the advantage that the lessons of the 'thirties and their application to the 'fifties, which are the themes of my memoirs, could be more easily displayed. It imposed a limitation, however, which I considered decisive. At least four years must elapse before my account of the more recent period could be presented. I thought that I should not wait so long. This book will expose wounds; by doing so it could help to heal them.

The years during which I held responsibility for the conduct of my country's foreign policy fell into two periods. The first was from 1935 until 1945, with a break of eighteen months from February 1938 until the early autumn of the following year, due to my resignation from Mr. Chamberlain's Government. I returned to Cabinet office, in company with Mr. Churchill, on the outbreak of war on September 3rd and became Foreign Secretary again towards the end of 1940.

The second period dates from the autumn of 1951 until January 1957, during the whole of which time I was either Foreign Secretary or Prime Minister. It is with this latter period that this volume deals, but the policies which I upheld and pursued during that time were based on my earlier experiences. In giving effect to them I found myself, from time to time, in disagreement with other opinions held in my own country and in allied countries. This has been a cause of regret to me.

So much of my life has been spent in the conduct or execution

of foreign policy that I feel I should set down these events as they presented themselves to me. The reflections and decisions I record in this volume are those which I formed at the time. I hope that this account and my reasoning, as well as the experiences I lived through, may be of service to others.

My material has consisted of the personal minutes which I wrote, often to Sir Winston Churchill as Prime Minister when I was Foreign Secretary, or to other colleagues when I was Prime Minister myself. Another source used has been the notes dictated to form the messages sent home when I was engaged upon a mission abroad, or sent abroad either to our embassies or to the statesmen of other lands. Yet another source has been the occasional notes jotted down at the moment and intended to be the basis for a fuller record when opportunity offered. But it is all the thought of the time on the action of the time set down at the time.

I considered that such an account could be useful because, though the pattern of world politics may be modified and its contours appear from time to time smoother or more menacing, nothing can change man's need to take counsel with all who have pursued the endless adventure.

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September, 1959

II

KOREAN CEASE-FIRE
October 1951 – July 1953

Armistice talks – Prisoners – Danger of communist attack – Retaliation against Chinese bases – Anglo-American agreement – Japanese Peace Treaty – A communist 'smear' – President Rhee – Indian resolution on prisoners – Intransigence of Mr. Vyshinsky – My discussion with M. Ruegger – President Rhee's right and left – Armistice signed

The United States, compounded of many elements, spread over a vast territory, facing two contrasting oceans, can express a national will, given leadership and the occasion. In the Korean crisis, Mr. Truman gave the lead and the response was firm. Over Quemoy and the Matsus, national opinion at a later time as effectively imposed restraint. It remains true that the executive has larger authority in the United States than in the European democracies with their smaller areas.

At the time of my return to the Foreign Office, the United States forces had been fighting in Korea for a year. Despite varying and vehemently expressed opinions by the lobbies, the policy which the United States Government was pursuing had national support. Throughout the fighting a determination that the aggressor should not get away with it had never varied. For this a heavy price was bravely paid, in young American life and countless treasure. The Government's declared purpose was to secure a workable armistice. I felt that they meant this and that they had no taste for war on the Chinese mainland. They understood the danger of that tar baby.

In this year exasperation with Chinese intervention had grown, but it did not provoke a national demand to take the war to the Chinese mainland, however fervently some might advocate this course.

ures: a naval blockade of China, and the bombing of Chinese airfields, bases and junctions north of the Yalu River. We informed them that we were unable to support a naval blockade, which could not be effective, but favoured the bombing plan, should the armistice terms be broken. No general air attack on Chinese towns was contemplated.

We discussed the terms of the warning with our allies. On December 16th, the United States Ambassador came to tell me that the State Department now thought that they could find a formula for the terms of a warning to the Chinese and North Koreans. This would be within the framework of the revised draft which we had proposed, and would declare our attitude in the event of a breach by them of any armistice concluded in Korea.

Mr. Gifford said that the United States Government thought that a warning statement ought to be issued, even if agreement was reached in the armistice talks about supervision, since there could be no confidence that such arrangements would be effective. They therefore did not share our view that, in certain circumstances, no warning would be required. I said that we were giving thought to this point, but it had not been the original form of the American suggestion. The Ambassador assented. He said finally that the United States Government realized that it was not possible for us to agree in advance on the minimum steps which might be taken, in the event of a major breach of the armistice. This matter would have to be hammered out if such an event occurred. Meanwhile it was understood that we were not committed to the steps which they had proposed, while they themselves still held to their proposals. This need not prevent us from issuing the warning.

The Labour Government had agreed in principle that, should the Chinese launch a major attack from beyond the Yalu River, the United Nations forces would retaliate by bombing the communist airfields in Manchuria. They had, however, insisted that they should be consulted before this was done. We held to this position, and we worked out methods to ensure that the time lag between attack and retaliation should be as small as possible. The final form of words which the two Governments accepted was a sensible compromise which ran, 'should aggression be committed again in Korea, the consequences would be so grave that it would, in all probability, not be possible to confine hostilities within the frontiers of Korea.'

When the Prime Minister and I visited the United States in January 1952, for talks with Mr. Truman and Mr. Acheson, the only commit-

ment we entered into was to despatch the warning message after the armistice was signed. The Americans described to us the action which they would wish to take against airfields north of the Yalu River in the event of any breach, but Mr. Acheson was careful to say that this was a matter on which we should no doubt want to consult our colleagues and have further discussions.

Another talk which I had with Mr. Acheson and Mr. Dulles during this visit, on January 10th, concerned a divergence of view between us which went back some little time. Mr. Truman had appointed Mr. Dulles as his special representative, with the rank of Ambassador, in order to negotiate the Japanese peace treaty, thus expressing the spirit of bipartisanship. The Labour Government, when in power, had always insisted, rightly I thought, that Japan's attitude towards the two Chinese Governments should be entirely her own concern. Mr. Herbert Morrison, who was then Foreign Secretary, and Mr. Dulles had, after discussion, agreed in June 1951 that neither would bring any pressure to bear on the Japanese one way or the other.

I shared these views, and held them all the more strongly for trade reasons. It was clear that if Japan was to have an outlet for her resurgent export trade, the Chinese mainland was the natural one. I thought it important that she should not be deprived of this by being led to adopt an inflexibly hostile attitude towards the Chinese People's Republic. If she did, she would regret it later, when her full sovereignty and independence had been restored by the ratification of the peace treaty.

When I discussed the matter with Mr. Acheson and Mr. Dulles, they explained to me the domestic political difficulties which the Administration faced on this issue. If Japan did not indicate that she intended to recognize Chiang Kai-shek's regime, then the 'China lobby' might be able to prevent ratification of the peace treaty by the Senate. I replied that I fully understood their position, but that the view of His Majesty's Government had not changed. Mr. Dulles had mentioned a communication he had received from Mr. Yoshida, the Japanese Prime Minister, and hinted that it might be necessary to use this during the Senate's debate on ratification. I was not shown the text, or informed that there was any immediate intention to make it public. I made it clear, however, that I must not be regarded as having acquiesced in the development which had taken place.

In view of this, I was surprised when a few days later the United States and Japanese Governments simultaneously published a letter from Mr. Yoshida to Mr. Dulles clearly stating the Japanese intention

to recognize the Nationalist regime in Formosa as the Government of China. Neither date nor announcement had been agreed with me. Its publication so soon after my visit to Washington was embarrassing, and could give the impression that I had agreed to its contents. Mr. Morrison, understandably, felt that the move was contrary to the spirit of his agreement with Mr. Dulles; and matters were not improved when an article in an American newspaper alleged, falsely, that he had known of the Japanese intention all along.

Through our Ambassador in Washington, I expressed to Mr. Acheson my surprise at the timing and manner of publication of the letter. In reply, Mr. Acheson conveyed his strong regret at what had occurred, and assured me that the fact that it might be seen in relation to my discussion with him was unintentional. He promised to re-state the position which I had always taken if he were questioned about the British attitude. This terminated an unnecessary misunderstanding.

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On my journey home I reflected on the plight of the unhappy Koreans. Geographically their country had some resemblance to the Low Countries of Europe in the pre-atomic days. It was a cockpit round which surged the great powers, Russia, China, Japan, the United States. Now it was being fought over because communist aggression had been resisted in the Far East. This could only be of limited comfort in many Korean homes, destroyed by war. The Koreans were not the first to learn that, while freedom is precious, 'liberation' is a high price to pay for it.

Fighting continued, and the extraordinary episode of the bacteria began. The Chinese Government suddenly opened a campaign of great violence against the Americans for the alleged use of germ warfare. They claimed to possess plenty of evidence in the form of unexploded canisters with various kinds of insects crawling out. The Indian Ambassador in Peking wisely counselled neutral inquiry by the International Red Cross. The Chinese replied that members of the international investigation team would only convey to the United Nations any military information which they were thus in a position to acquire. This seemed to me a suspiciously weak objection.

Mr. Acheson at once proposed an investigation by the International Red Cross and supported an offer of help to victims by the World Health Organization. The Chinese Government refused any form of

IV

THE SUMMIT
July 1955

I talk to President Eisenhower and M. Faure – Our agreement – First plenary session – Russian objections to a united Germany – Characters of Marshal Bulganin and Mr. Khrushchev – Our discussion at dinner – Russian memories – A proposed non-aggression pact – Disarmament – The order of the agenda – A compromise – Final speeches – I invite the Russian leaders to England – Hospitality at the conference – The off-shore islands – Russian and American views – A verdict on the conference – I return to England

The Foreign Secretaries of the three Western powers met in Paris on July 15th to put the finishing touches to the preparations for the Geneva meeting. It had been arranged that after the opening discussion, the Heads of Government should meet in the afternoons and the Foreign Secretaries in the mornings. As a result of our work, we hoped to agree upon the subjects and terms of reference for the Foreign Secretaries at their later meeting in the autumn. I wanted to preserve freedom in our arrangements.

We flew to Geneva on the afternoon of Saturday, July 16th. My wife and I returned to the house which had been lent to us by its owner, M. Pictet, during the Indo-China Conference. Le Reposoir was a pleasant blend of French and Swiss architecture of the eighteenth century, a graceful home which we enjoyed. Next morning M. Faure and I joined Mr. Eisenhower for an informal meeting at his villa, where we discussed the statements we would make at the opening of the conference. They were to be published; the further development of our ideas was to take place in private.

I told the President and M. Faure that I considered German unifica-

by nuclear weapons. Here I felt was the likely pattern of future events.

On July 22nd, the Soviet delegation gave a dinner for me. Afterwards Marshal Bulganin drew me out on to the terrace, which overlooked the garden of the small villa they occupied. He began to speak of a visit by me to Moscow. He said that it had been many years since I was last there, in the war, and now conditions were greatly changed. I could be sure that the Russian people would give me a great welcome. I thanked Marshal Bulganin for his invitation and explained, as I had done before, that I had already paid many visits to Russia and that my work at home could hardly allow of another journey at present. I added that if anyone was to do any travelling, it was really the turn of the Russians to visit us. The Marshal smiled and replied that he accepted this. Stalin had never liked to travel. He himself had no similar feelings on the subject, neither had Mr. Khrushchev. They probably would be going abroad and would like to come to London. I said that this would certainly be welcome to me and to my colleagues.

I thought that it would be useful to renew the contacts we had established at Geneva. In London we could have thorough discussions at our leisure on the many problems that troubled the world. I would also like to give our visitors a chance to see something of the country. It was a mistake to suppose that all Britain was to be found in London. Marshal Bulganin responded readily to all this and, with Mr. Khrushchev, who had joined us during the conversation, expressing the same sentiments, the matter was soon arranged.

I had expected that something of this kind might happen during my visit to Geneva. It had seemed prudent to sound one or two of my colleagues in London in advance. I had no doubt, therefore, that this decision would be welcome to the Cabinet, as it was later to Parliament. I told Mr. Eisenhower at once of these developments and the same reaction was understanding.

For those of us who had been familiar with the long, black, bullet-proof cars of the Russians, it was a surprise to note the turn-out of the new Soviet leaders. They seemed to take pride in the minimum of display, and drove to and fro in an open car, with the smallest of police escorts. This was, no doubt, intended to show a fair similarity to the habit of French and British Prime Ministers. It was in some contrast to the President of the United States, who, alone among us, was a Head of State. He had to endure the road-sweeping tactics of the Secret Service, which seemed a little out of proportion in the scale of democratic Switzerland.

At times, this new-found Soviet enthusiasm for free and easy methods led to some discomfort. In the later afternoon of the final day of the conference, I went round to see the Russian leaders, in company with Sir Harold Caccia, then a Deputy Under-Secretary of State at the Foreign Office. Mr. Macmillan was to meet me there and we were to talk over the Geneva accords affecting Indo-China, negotiated a year before. On my arrival, I saw a large number of photographers of various nationalities by the front door. I paid little attention and walked through into the garden where Marshal Bulganin and Mr. Khrushchev and others were standing. I had hardly shaken hands, when the earth shook with the trampling of a herd of buffaloes and the photographers broke through from all directions. Our small island was soon almost overwhelmed. One over-excited photographer jabbed me furiously in the back, crying, 'Get out of my way, can't you?' I did not oblige. Eventually, perplexed by this display of western manners, the Russian leaders contrived to shepherd their guests into the house.

At a conference like this, it is usual for private discussions to be the most worthwhile. We entertained each other informally and made working occasions of the meals. Apart from attending a dinner given by our Swiss hosts, the President was firm in taking all his meals at home. He had brought his own Filipinos to cook for him and they had brought their frozen steaks from the United States. M. Faure was a convivial host and regaled us with *vin jaune* from the Jura nearby. This was his own country and he took a justifiable pride in its local wine, which is pleasantly refreshing when drunk on the spot.

Our formal meetings were concerned with Europe, our private anxieties with the Far East. I soon learnt that the other delegations at the conference thought there was no immediate danger of war in Europe. It was equally clear that all were deeply concerned at the situation in the Far East, especially that of the off-shore islands of Quemoy and the Matsus. The United States might declare that they owed nothing to Chiang Kai-shek, but he was necessary to the defence of Formosa, or so at least the Americans believed, and Formosa formed part of the United States Pacific defences. No Chinese Government could be expected to accept this, though they might tolerate it under repeated protests. The Formosans themselves would probably prefer to lead their own lives, without either Chiang or Peking to dominate them.

The off-shore islands were in a different category. They had always been part of China, and were garrisoned and defended by Chiang

Kai-shek. No great power could seriously want to fight about them, yet they could be a cause of war, just the same. They were never mentioned at the conference table, but they were the world's flash point in the summer of 1955. I am convinced that the Geneva Conference damped their explosive force, for the time being at least.

Clearly this was not a topic likely to yield to direct United States and Soviet talks, but I had no inhibitions about taking a hand in it myself. After a detailed conversation alone with the President, I was absolutely convinced of American sincerity. The Americans knew that they had a bear by the tail. I soon found that the Soviet leaders shared my concern at the danger, while persistently upholding their ally's standpoint. In one of our informal discussions Mr. Khrushchev commented that the Chinese had been very patient; he did not think that the Russians would have been so patient. I replied that he underestimated his own statesmanship. The position of Quemoy and the Matsus was very difficult for the Americans and for everybody concerned. The Americans might wish their ally to take steps he was not prepared to take. We were not always able to get our friends to do what we wanted. The Russians appeared to accept this, but they were clearly still anxious about the Far Eastern situation.

As these informal exchanges proceeded, I felt increasingly convinced that all the member powers wished to avoid conflict in the area. This, I believed, also applied to the Chinese Government of Peking, though, as the Russians commented, 'The master of the house is absent.' I thought that it might even suit the Chinese Communists to have Chiang's forces on the off-shore islands. They constituted a constant grievance with which most of world opinion would sympathize. The islands were militarily vulnerable and could be harassed or bombarded by conventional weapons at any time, when Chiang would have to evacuate or supply them. The former would be a humiliation, the latter costly in supplies and perhaps in life. On the other hand, if Chiang were soon to evacuate Quemoy and the Matsus, as he had Tachen, then the Chinese Communist case against Chiang and the United States would be much weaker, politically and militarily. World opinion would not feel about Formosa, with its chequered history and so recently Japanese, as it did about small islands in the mouths of Chinese harbours and rivers. Militarily, the Chinese Communists could do little that was effective to threaten Formosa, so long as it was part of the United States defensive chain. To get there, they would have to swim or fly against a formidable fortress a hundred

miles away. Therefore, from the American point of view, the position in Formosa would be stronger without the commitment of the off-shore islands.

It seemed to me that here was an occasion where time was on the side of peace. Already in Formosa the army was changing its character. It was becoming composed more and more of young Formosans, who did not want to return to the mainland. As that development continued, the off-shore islands would matter less. In the talks I held, I did everything I could to persuade those present, and absent, of the peaceful intentions of the other side.

On the evening when I dined with the Russians, Marshal Bulganin and Mr. Khrushchev spoke of the position in the Far East. Marshal Zhukov was also present, but he took no part in the conversation. My hosts said that they had been greatly impressed by what they had seen during their visit to China. The new leaders there were men to be reckoned with. Both Mao Tse-tung and Chou En-lai were strong characters, men of balanced judgment, who were unlikely to take hasty or ill-considered action. The regime was firmly established; much material progress was being made and, in ten years or so, China would be a strong modern state. Meanwhile, their revolution was young. It was natural, therefore, that they should resent Chiang's occupation of Quemoy and the Matsus so near their coastline, and the United States protection of Chiang in Formosa. It was natural, too, that they should wish to take China's seat in the United Nations. On that point the Russians claimed that they certainly had right on their side.

I said that President Eisenhower was doing his best to steady public opinion in the United States on the subject of Quemoy and the Matsus. The Russians should, however, recognize his difficulties. This was a subject on which emotions ran high in the United States. Our own interests in China had been mainly commercial. We had traded there for a long time, and over the years had earned a good return for what we had invested. The Americans, during the war and since, had poured money into China, and the average American now felt that the Chinese had bitten the hand that fed them. As a result, the Americans were specially sensitive about the present situation. The President was trying, in spite of this, to calm things down. If he were given more time, all might yet be well. Were the Chinese prepared to be equally patient?

Mr. Khrushchev said that traditionally the Chinese were a patient people. He believed that they would not take any rash action at the

present time. It was to be hoped, however, that some fruitful result would come from the meetings which were to be held in Geneva between two ambassadors appointed by the United States and China. I said that these discussions should help. Though they would begin with such questions as release of prisoners, they might well broaden out to cover some of the more substantial issues.

The Geneva meeting was worthwhile if only for the discreet improvement it brought about in the Formosa Strait. By the end of the conference, the Foreign Secretary and I were convinced that all present would have been sincerely happy to see the off-shore islands sunk under the sea. All this seemed to justify the comment I made to the House of Commons on my return: 'Geneva has given this simple message to the whole world: it has reduced the dangers of war.'

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The day following our return, my wife and I drove to Winchester, where my regiment was celebrating its two hundredth anniversary. The King's Royal Rifle Corps (60th Rifles) began life on the American continent in the mid-eighteenth century, under the title of the Royal American Regiment. Swift in movement and dark green in uniform, it was formed to aid and cover the more cumbrous manœuvres of the traditional red-coats, against the French and their Red Indian allies. The American connection has existed ever since. When, in the second world war, a number of young Americans volunteered to join the British Army before Pearl Harbour, it was natural that the 60th should be their choice. They served bravely in the North African campaign, some staying with the regiment throughout the war. It was moving to meet a number of the survivors once again, on this afternoon of memories in a perfect English setting.

The Queen, our Colonel-in-Chief, took the salute. The drill movements to the note of the bugle and the double past made a dashing and unusual spectacle in which I took pride. Later that afternoon I had an audience of Her Majesty at the Deanery in Winchester, and reported on the Geneva meeting and the projected Russian visit. As my wife and I drove back through the city to our cottage near Salisbury, the citizens gave us a splendid greeting, the countryside was fresh and green in the evening light. These interludes are rare in the life of a Prime Minister.